

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Winter storm

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stay indoors and postpone travel during dangerous snow, ice or blowing snow. Keep heat safe, use battery lighting and watch for power loss. If stranded in a vehicle, stay with it unless a safer shelter is clearly accessible.

Do now.

**Check road conditions**

01

Use official closures and forecasts before deciding to travel.

**Keep warmth safe**

02

Wear dry layers; never heat a home with an oven, grill or indoor generator.

**Prepare for outages**

03

Keep essential medicines, water, food, light and charged batteries accessible.

**If stranded**

04

Call for help with your location. If running the engine briefly for heat, first clear snow from the exhaust and crack a window; monitor for carbon monoxide.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Keep dry layers, safe food, water and battery light together. If stranded in a vehicle, keep the exhaust clear before running the engine and conserve fuel; do not sleep with the engine running. Remain with the vehicle when walking would expose you to poor visibility or severe cold.

Watch for.

Do not walk away from a stranded vehicle in poor visibility unless you know a safe nearby destination.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check road conditions. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not walk away from a stranded vehicle in poor visibility unless you know a safe nearby destination.

Keep essentials within reach.

For winter storm, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Keep dry layers, safe food, water and battery light together. If stranded in a vehicle, keep the exhaust clear before running the engine and conserve fuel; do not sleep with the engine running. Remain with the vehicle when walking would expose you to poor visibility or severe cold. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Check on people who rely on powered equipment or may lack safe heat. Arrange relocation before indoor temperatures become dangerous.

First decision: Check road conditions

Use official closures and forecasts before deciding to travel. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Keep dry layers, safe food, water and battery light together. If stranded in a vehicle, keep the exhaust clear before running the engine and conserve fuel; do not sleep with the engine running. Remain with the vehicle when walking would expose you to poor visibility or severe cold. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not walk away from a stranded vehicle in poor visibility unless you know a safe nearby destination. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Stay indoors and postpone travel during dangerous snow, ice or blowing snow. Keep heat safe, use battery lighting and watch for power loss. If stranded in a vehicle, stay with it unless a safer shelter is clearly accessible. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For winter storm, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not walk away from a stranded vehicle in poor visibility unless you know a safe nearby destination.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: If stranded. Call for help with your location. If running the engine briefly for heat, first clear snow from the exhaust and crack a window; monitor for carbon monoxide. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Winter storm · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/winter>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/winter-storm/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.